



US plate and HRC prices continue to rise, Chinese HRC softens

Trade policy supports Western market prices, demand remains key concern

The recent dynamics in the Middle East have started to weigh on sentiment and a negative impact on demand remains the main concern in the near term. Nevertheless, Western prices and margins have been firm so far and the EU's plans for a significant step-up in trade protection should ultimately support a sustained rebound in European spreads, while the impact from CBAM adds to that. Hence, we maintain our constructive view on the sector. We published our take on the latest EU policy development last week ([link](#)). Our top picks in carbon steel are: Voestalpine (VOES.VI; Buy; EUR47.36; TP: EUR57), which remains the most solid equity story, based on steady FCF generation (despite peak decarb capex), self-help and an undervalued rail-infrastructure business; and thyssenkrupp (TKAG.DE; Buy; EUR11.39; TP: EUR14.50) on possible catalysts and policy tailwinds in steel. We recently upgraded the stock ([link](#)). In stainless steel, we prefer Acerinox (ACX.MC; Buy; EUR15.54; TP: EUR16), based on its exposure to the attractive US market and its solid cash returns. We also continue to like Aperam (APAM.AS; Buy; EUR50.90; TP: EUR65), based on its reversion potential and organic growth prospects, coupled with its strong mid-cycle FCF-generating ability and shareholder returns.

Northern European HRC prices stable

Last week, indications for northern European HRC prices were up EUR2/t to the EUR680-695/t range (up USD3/t in USD terms to USD795-805/t). Southern European prices were down EUR8/t to the EUR675-685/t range (down USD9/t to USD785-795/t). The BOF price spread for German HRC vs the cost of key raw materials has increased to USD231/t (vs USD227/t last week), which is still significantly above mid-cycle levels. Marginal players remain around mid-cycle levels.

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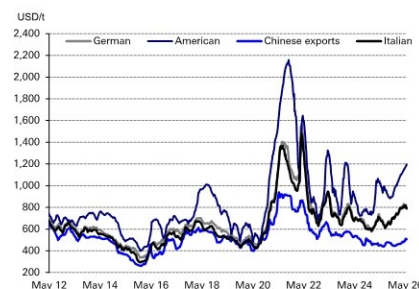
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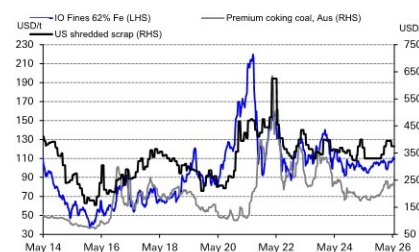
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Figure 1: HRC prices



Source : CRU, Argus Media

Figure 2: Raw material prices



Source : Kallanish, Bloomberg Finance LP

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US HRC and plate remain strong

Last week, US HRC prices were up USD13/t to the USD1190-1205/t range, and market sentiment remains strong on the back of solid lead times and domestic pricing discipline. Prices are up USD196/t this year. The BOF price spread vs the cost of key raw materials stands at USD638/t (up USD15/t vs the previous week). The EAF spread (HRC vs scrap) stands at USD616/t (up USD13/t vs the previous week). After fresh price hikes, US plate prices were up USD13/t to the USD1,350-1,365/t range and prices are currently up ~USD266/t in 2026.

Chinese export prices down

Chinese domestic rebar prices were up RMB33/t to RMB3,331/t, while HRC prices were down RMB72/t to RMB3,413/t. Rebar prices have increased RMB125/t over the past three months, while HRC prices have increased RMB168/t. Chinese HRC export prices stand at USD500-510/t (down USD5/t vs last week). Considering transport costs and the 50% S232 duty, this implies a US parity price of USD910-930/t.

Iron ore prices down

Iron ore (62% Fe) prices were down USD2/t to the USD108-110/t range last week. Coal prices were stable at the USD235-245/t range. US scrap prices were stable at the USD370-380/t range, while European scrap prices were down USD1/t to the USD360-375/t range.



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Steel price summary

Figure 3: Steel price summary

Prices for the week May 15 - May 22		Price per tonne						Absolute change (USD)						% change (USD)					
Index		USD	1w	1m	3m	ytd	y/y	1w	1m	3m	ytd	y/y	1w	1m	3m	ytd	y/y	1w	1m
Hot Rolled Coil (HRC)																			
Germany	795-805		3	-14	0	67	112	0	-2	0	9	16							
Italy	785-795		-9	-21	-5	49	111	-1	-3	-1	7	16							
USA	1190-1205		13	41	109	196	207	1	4	10	20	21							
Chinese exports	500-510		-5	10	42	52	53	-1	2	9	11	12							
Cold Rolled Coil (CRC)																			
Germany	910-925		0	-18	-20	58	110	0	-2	-2	7	14							
Italy	925-935		0	-15	-8	70	131	0	-2	-1	8	16							
USA	1375-1390		23	69	134	184	161	2	5	11	15	13							
Hot Dipped Galvanised Coil (HDG)																			
Germany	920-930		0	-15	-2	64	111	0	-2	0	7	14							
Italy	920-930		-9	-24	-2	58	122	-1	-2	0	7	15							
USA	1475-1485		17	76	175	249	248	1	5	13	20	20							
Plate																			
Germany	950-960		2	2	76	127	119	0	0	9	15	14							
Italy	910-920		1	12	51	131	172	0	1	6	17	23							
USA	1350-1365		13	72	183	266	93	1	6	16	24	7							
Rebar																			
Germany	820-830		6	74	106	128	90	1	10	15	18	12							
USA	1050-1065		0	28	11	66	220	0	3	1	7	26							
Iron ore as of 22 May 2026																			
Fines 62% Fe	108-110		-2	2	11	3	9	-1	2	11	3	9							
Scrap as of 21 May 2026																			
US	370-380		0	0	-20	30	45	0	0	-5	9	14							
Europe	360-375		-1	8	26	37	44	0	2	8	11	14							
Coking coal as of 22 May 2026																			
Premium Coking Coal / Australian Exports	235-245		0	8	-6	19	50	0	3	-2	9	26							

Source : Deutsche Bank, CRU, Argus Media, Kallanish, Bloomberg Finance LP

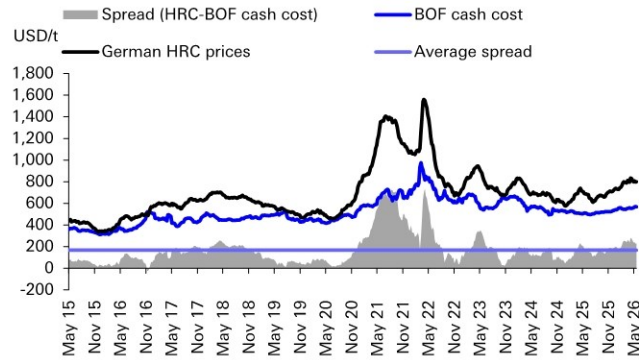
Industry valuation and risks

We use various methodologies to value the steel companies under our coverage – from a DCF-based valuation to a normalised earnings approach and a sum-of-the-parts (SOTP) analysis. Key industry risks include (1) global economic growth not meeting/exceeding expectations; (2) lower- or higher-than-expected steel prices, which could result in an erosion of, or a boost to, earnings; (3) higher/lower raw material and other operating costs, which could limit/help earnings growth; (4) political influence of governments on the steel trade; (5) expansion projects failing to progress as expected; and (6) M&A valuation and integration risks.



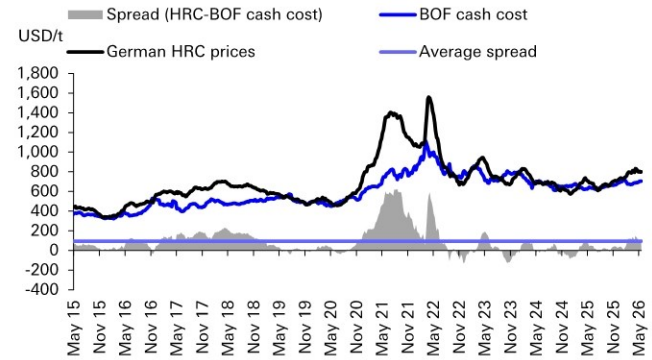
Spreads and cash costs

Figure 4: German HRC vs BOF HRC cash costs (average producers)



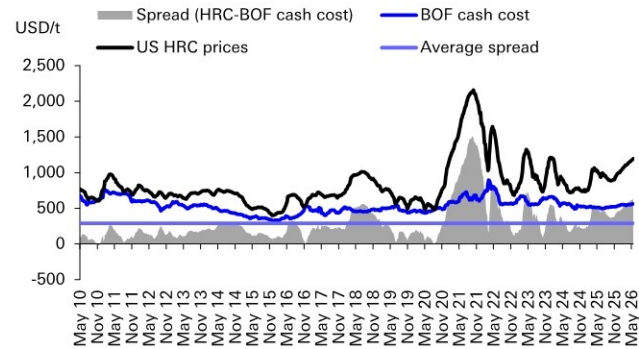
Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Argus Media

Figure 5: German HRC vs BOF HRC cash costs (marginal producers with full CO₂ cost)



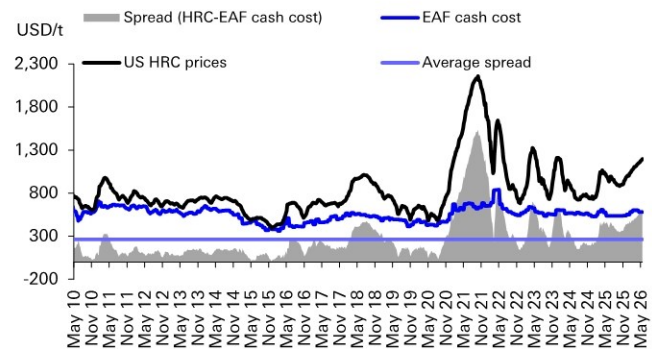
Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Argus Media

Figure 6: US HRC vs BOF HRC cash costs



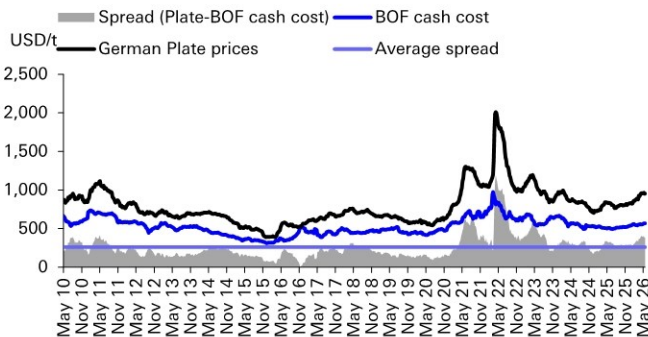
Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, CRU

Figure 7: US HRC vs EAF HRC cash costs



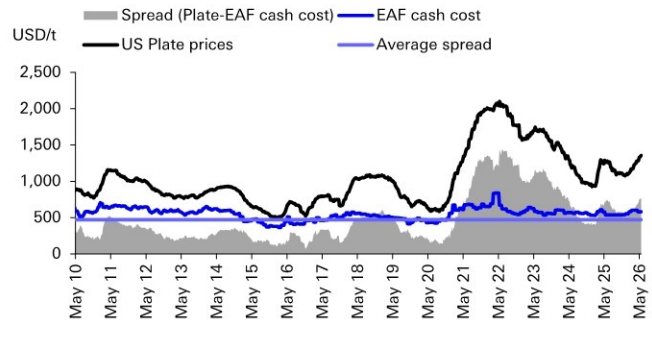
Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, CRU

Figure 8: German plate vs BOF cash costs



Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Argus Media

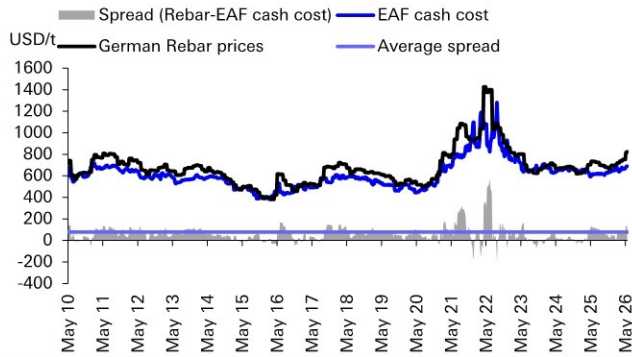
Figure 9: US plate vs EAF cash costs



Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, CRU

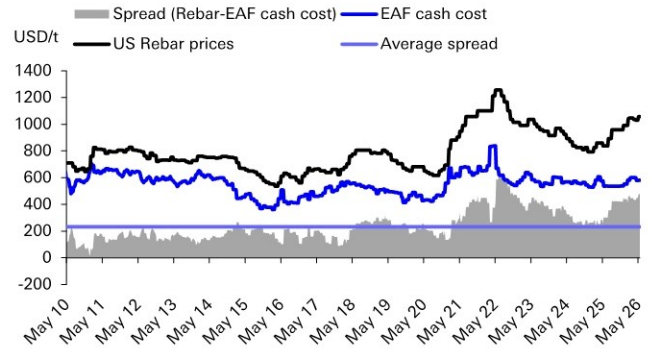


Figure 10: German rebar vs EAF cash costs



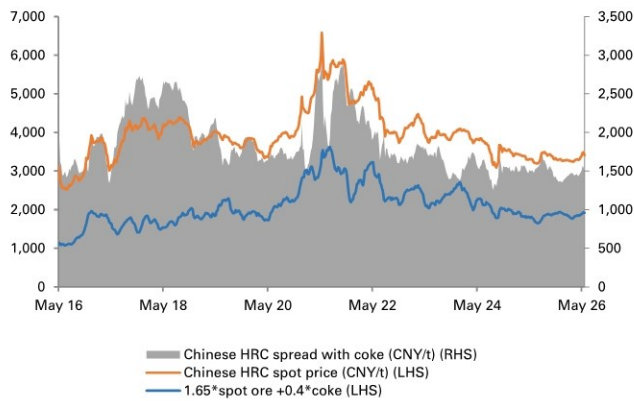
Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Argus Media

Figure 11: US rebar vs EAF cash costs



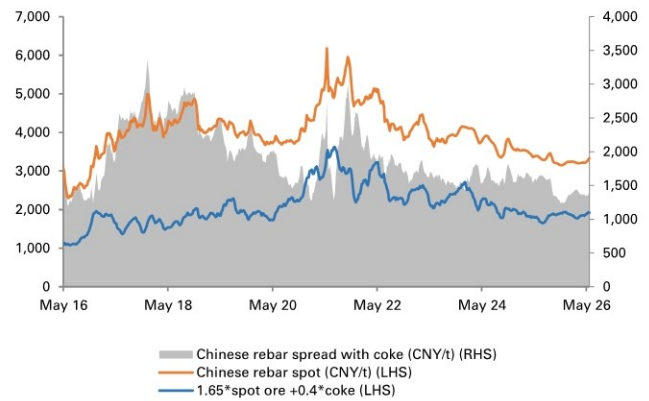
Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, CRU

Figure 12: Chinese HRC price-cost spread (using coke)



Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Bloomberg Finance LP

Figure 13: Chinese rebar price-cost spread (using coke)

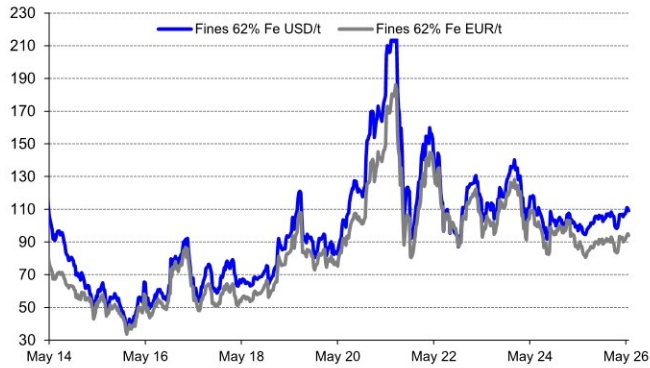


Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Bloomberg Finance LP



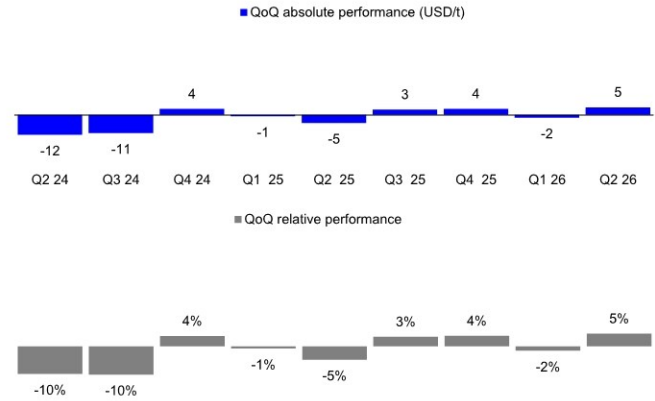
Primary steel-making raw material prices

Figure 14: Fines 62% Fe, CFR Tianjin Port, China



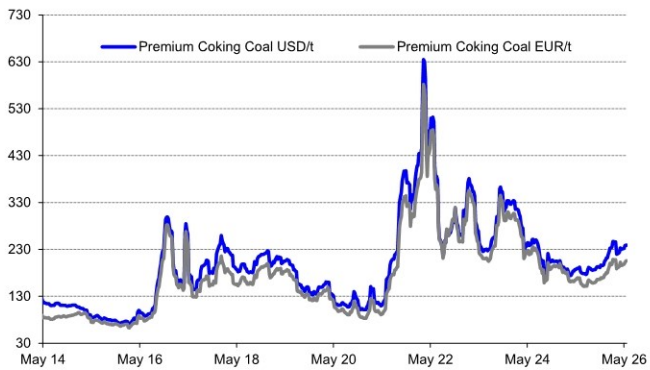
Source : Bloomberg Finance LP

Figure 15: QoQ performance



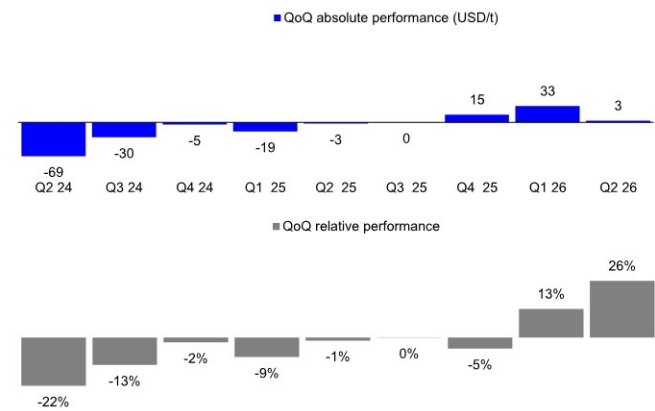
Source : Bloomberg Finance LP

Figure 16: Premium coking coal (Australian exports)



Source : Bloomberg Finance LP

Figure 17: QoQ performance

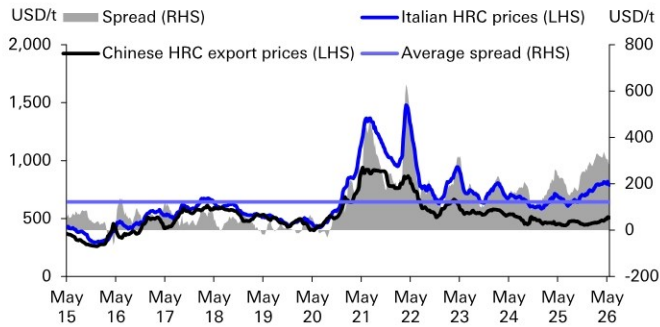


Source : Bloomberg Finance LP



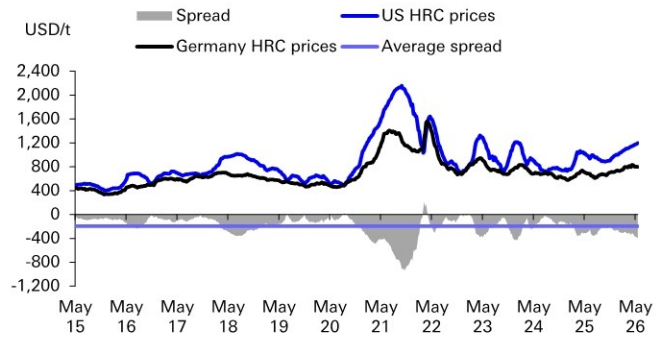
Regional spreads and trade statistics

Figure 18: Italian HRC vs Chinese HRC



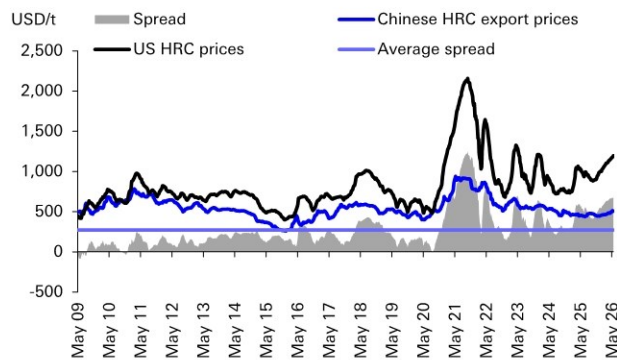
Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Argus Media

Figure 19: German HRC vs US HRC



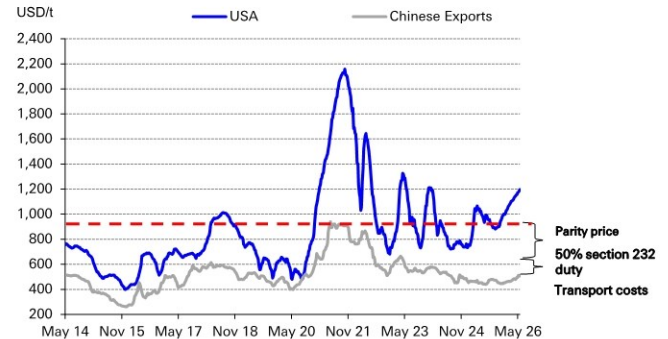
Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Argus Media

Figure 20: US HRC vs Chinese HRC



Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Argus Media, CRU

Figure 21: US HRC vs Chinese HRC parity price



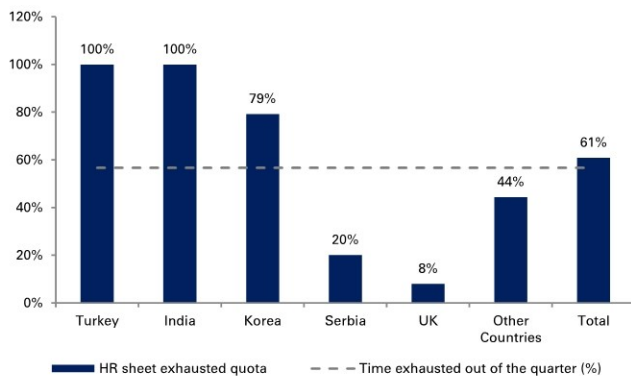
Source : Deutsche Bank estimates, Kallanish



EU safeguard-quota utilisation

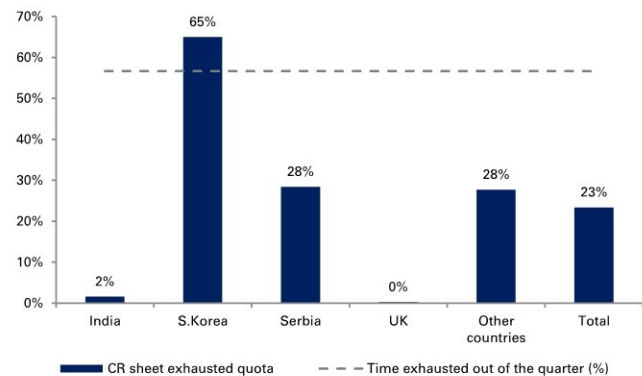
We entered a new quota period on 1 April 2026. The balance from the previous quarter was rolled over two weeks back. Hence, current balances for all the categories are with respect to adjusted numbers with previous balances wherever applicable. As of 22 May 2026, some categories have seen significant material inflow with 61% of HR sheet, 23% of CR, 56-65% of coated sheet and 49% of plate quotas already utilised. The entire country specific quarterly quota for Indian and Turkish HRC and Chinese coated sheet (4b) is exhausted while 92% of the S.Korean coated sheet (4a) quota has also been used. Overall, the quota usage remains lower than previous quarters in most of the categories. The European Commission has announced its proposal for the new trade protection regime, which is encouraging. All eyes will now be on the European Parliament final decision in May.

Figure 22: HR sheet exhausted-quota status



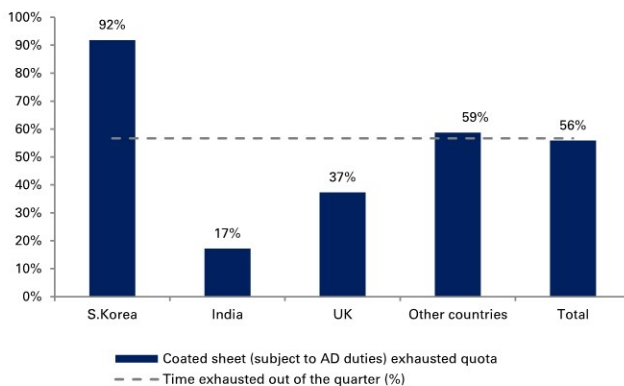
Source : European Commission

Figure 23: CR sheet exhausted-quota status



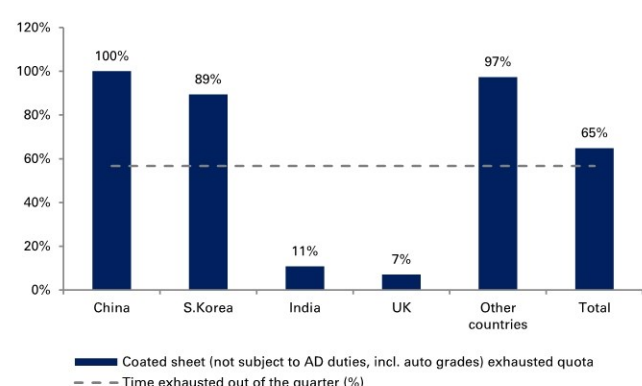
Source : European Commission

Figure 24: Coated sheet (subject to AD duties) exhausted-quota status



Source : European Commission

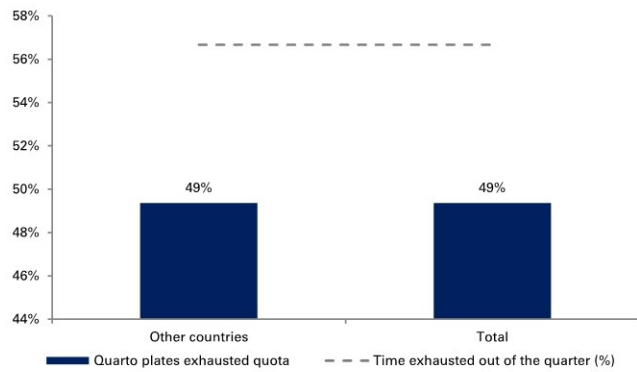
Figure 25: Coated sheet (not subject to AD duties, including auto grades) exhausted-quota status



Source : European Commission

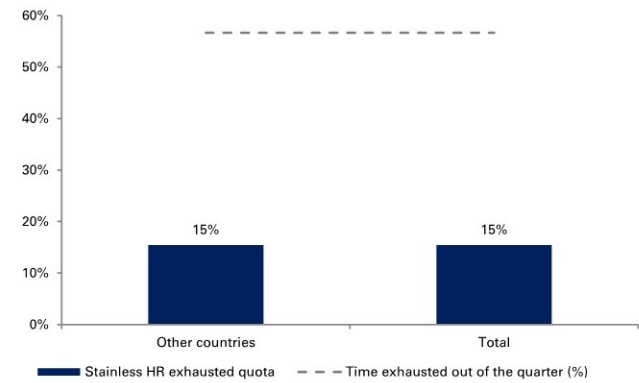


Figure 26: Quarto plates exhausted-quota status



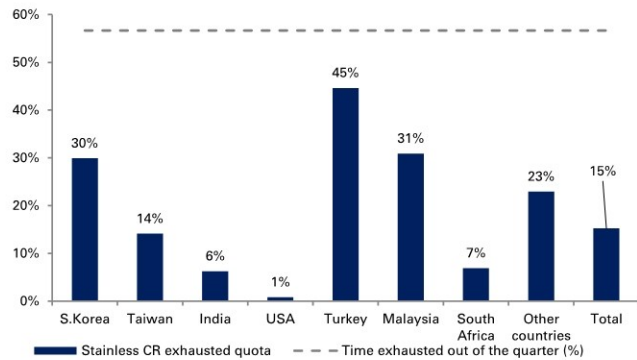
Source : European Commission

Figure 27: Stainless HR exhausted-quota status



Source : European Commission

Figure 28: Stainless CR exhausted-quota status

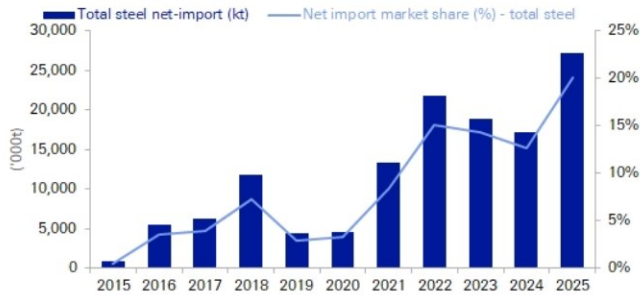


Source : European Commission



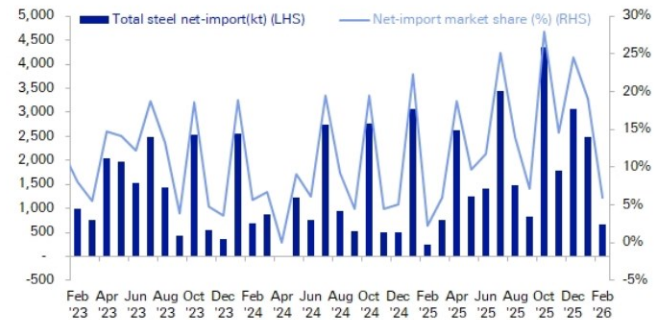
Key regional trade statistics

Figure 29: Total steel net imports vs net-import market share (%) – EU27+UK (long term)



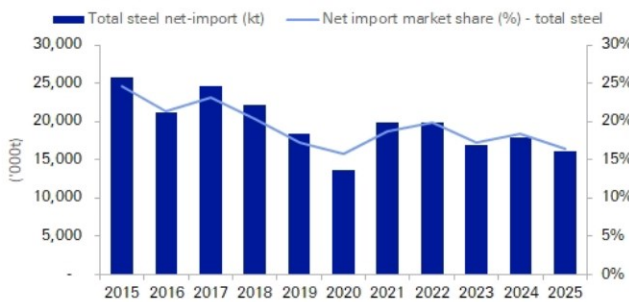
Source : Deutsche Bank, Eurostat

Figure 30: Total steel net imports vs net-import market share (%) – EU27+UK (monthly)



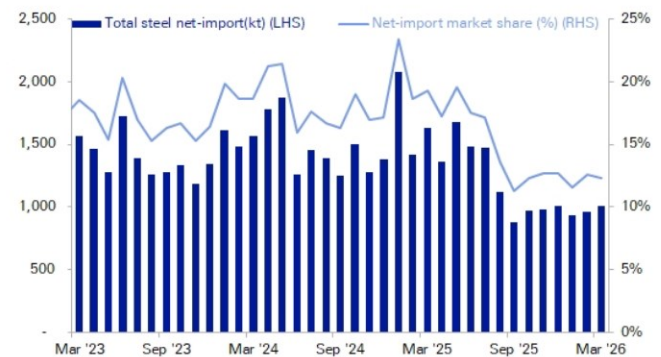
Source : Deutsche Bank, Eurostat

Figure 31: Total steel net imports vs net-import market share (%) – USA (long term)



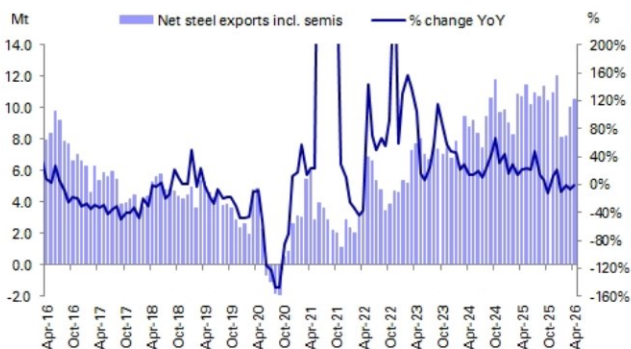
Source : Deutsche Bank, USITA

Figure 32: Total steel net imports vs net-import market share (%) – USA (monthly)



Source : Deutsche Bank, USITA

Figure 33: China net steel exports (including semi-finished steel)



Source : Deutsche Bank, Bloomberg Finance LP

Figure 34: China implied steel demand (3mma) and y/y growth (%)



Source : Deutsche Bank, Bloomberg Finance LP



Appendix 1

Important Disclosures

*Other information available upon request

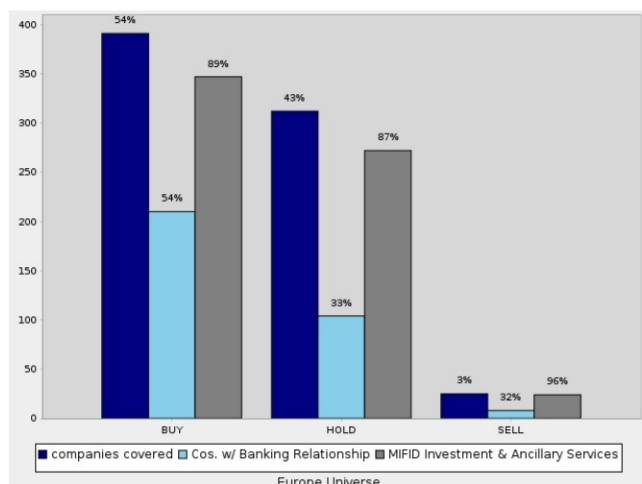
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Equity rating dispersion and banking relationships



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The Equity Rating Dispersion Chart depicts the following:

The proportion of recommendations that are rated "buy", "sell" and "hold" over the previous 12 months. This is shown for securities issued in the stated region e.g. "Europe Universe". See rating definitions below. This is represented by the "Companies Covered" bars in the chart. The percentage value displayed above the bar is the proportion as a percentage. E.g. 50% above the "buy" / "Companies Covered" bar means that 50% of DB's equity research covered companies over the past 12 months have a "buy" rating.

Next to each of the three respective bars showing the proportion of "buy", "sell" and "hold" recommendations we provide two additional bars to show:

- The proportion of "buy", "sell" or "hold" recommendations where Deutsche Bank and or/Affiliates provided MIFID Investment or Ancillary Services in the past 12 months. This is represented in the "MIFID Investment and Ancillary Services" bar. The percentage value displayed above the bar shows the proportion of Companies Covered with the given rating where DB has also provided MIFID Investment and Ancillary Services in the past 12 months. E.g. 50% above the "Cos. w/ MIFID Investment and Ancillary Services" bar means 50% of the Companies Covered with the rating stated have also received MIFID Investment and Ancillary Services from DB.

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Buy: Based on a current 12- month view of TSR, we recommend that investors buy the stock.

Sell: Based on a current 12-month view of TSR, we recommend that investors sell the stock.

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TSR = Total Shareholder Return. Percentage change in share price from current price to projected target price plus projected dividend yield

Newly issued research recommendations and target prices supersede previously published research.



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